

BASIC SIGHT-SINGING AND EAR TRAINING FOR CHURCH SINGERS

UNIT 8.1 – FORMS AND STRUCTURES

CATEGORIES OF MELODIES IN ORTHODOX CHANT —

TROPARIA



THE FORM AND STRUCTURE OF TROPARIA MELODIES

In Unit 6.1 (Slides 5 & 6) and Form Analysis Exercises 6.1 (Slides 3 thru 7) we already introduced the concept of **structured patterns** as well as some specific examples of the **melodic phrases**—used for **troparia** in the system of “Common” Chant (a.k.a. “Russian Imperial Chapel” Chant). In this unit we present a more complete picture of the melodies for singing troparia, including some frequently used variants, along with some analytical comments; as examples, we are using the Resurrectional (Sunday) Troparia.

As mentioned before, a **troparion** is a **short poetic verse**, usually consisting of four to eight phrases, which concisely describes the occasion or personage being celebrated. Every day of the liturgical year has one or more troparia assigned to it.

Troparia melodies are also used for singing **kontakia** and **kathisma hymns** at Matins, though the latter are frequently read. Originally kontakia were complex multi-strophed poems, but in modern-day usage, they are very similar in structure and content to troparia.

STUDY NOTES FOR THE SLIDES THAT FOLLOW

For each Tone presented in the following slides:

1. Read the Analysis and observe and identify the “Things to notice” in each Troparion that follows.
2. In the Form Analysis Exercises 8.1 you will be asked to make **your own** analysis of each troparion Tone, based on the information presented in this unit.
3. Do the Form Analysis Exercises without looking at the examples in this unit, then use them to check your work.

TROPARION TONE 1 (COMMON CHANT) - ANALYSIS

In its most basic form, the troparion melody for Tone 1 consists of two melodic phrases (1, 2) sung in alternation and repeated as required by the number of phrases in the text. The last (Final) phrase is identical to Phrase 2, so there is no unique Final phrase (see **Variant 1**, Slide 7 thru 9).

Ideally, the form of the musical phrases of the Tones are in agreement with the grammatical structure of the text. An example of this would be a “When... then...” structure: “When (this happened)... then (this happened).”

**When You, O Lord, were baptized in the Jordan,
the worship of the Trinity was made manifest.**

The two-phrase structure of Troparion Tone 1 (in Variant 1) is in ideal agreement with this type of text.

TROPARION TONE 1 ANALYSIS - 2

However, this is not always the case: sometimes a text may contain an additional statement, as in the Troparion for the Meeting of the Lord.

**Rejoice, O Virgin Theotokos, full of grace:
from you shone the Sun of Righteousness, Christ our God,
enlightening those who sat in darkness.**

This three-phrase text structure is best accommodated by the use of a **bridge phrase** (Phrase 2a), which extends the musical structure before coming to rest (cadencing) on Phrase 2b. This is illustrated in **Variant 2** of Troparion Tone 1 (Slides 10-12).

In practice, the Resurrectional (Sunday) Troparion in Tone 1 exists in both Variant 1 and Variant 2, as shown on the slides that follow. In Variant 1, the “agreement” between the musical and textual structures is not as optimal as in Variant 2.

TROPARION TONE 1 ANALYSIS - 3

Things to notice:

1. Troparion Tone 1 is typically written in the key of F Major or the key of G Major.
2. The starting note, F (or G), is DO, as is the final note.
3. In Variant 1, the melody “departs” from DO and goes up the scale to FA, then “returns” back from MI to DO in Phrase 2.
4. In Variant 2, however, Phrase 2a “pivots” from MI again up to FA, then “returns” back from MI to DO in Phrase 2b.
5. Thus, Phrase 2 in Variant 1 is identical to Phrase 2b of Variant 2.

QUESTION: Is the music-text agreement in Variant 1 better or worse than in Variant 2. Why or why not?

TROPARION TONE 1 (COMMON CHANT) - VARIANT 1 (p. 1)

TROPARION OF THE RESURRECTION Tone 1

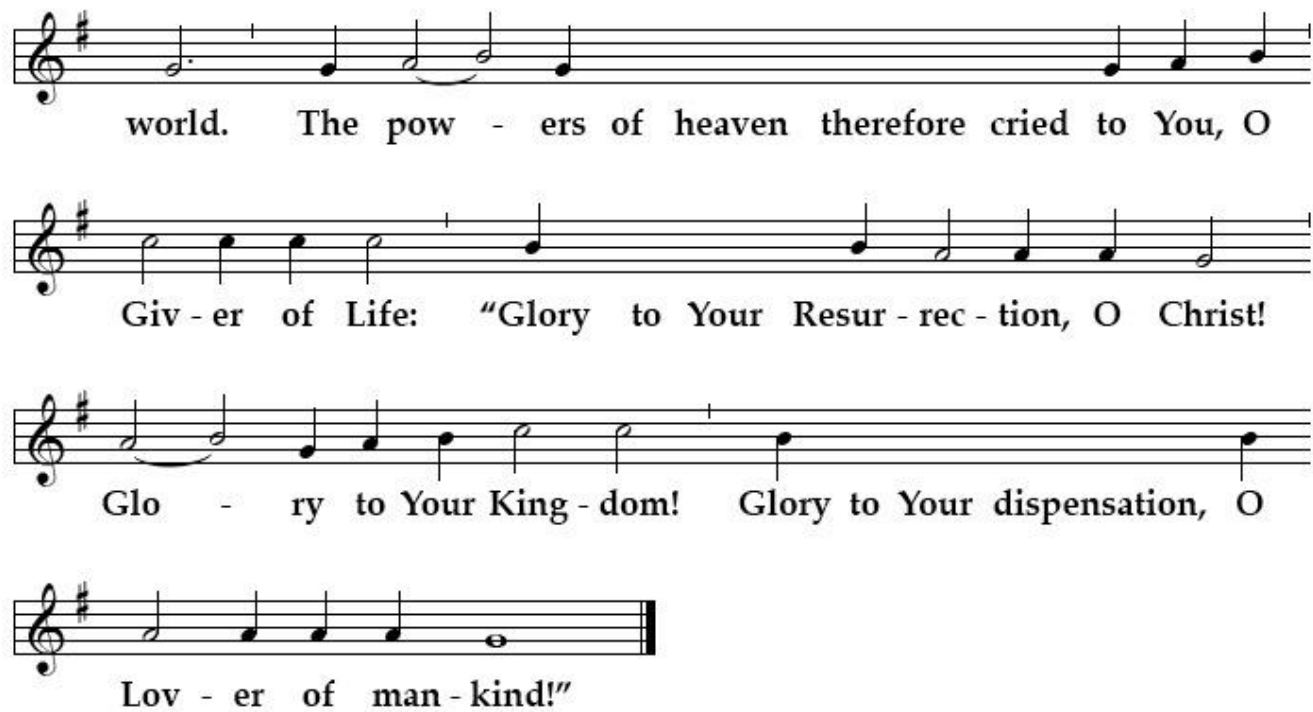
Russian Imperial Court Chant
arr. from Lvov/Bakhmetev

When the stone__ had been sealed by the Jews,

while the soldiers were guarding Your most pure bod - y,

You rose__ on the third day, O Sav - ior, grant-ing life to the

TROPARION TONE 1 (COMMON CHANT) - VARIANT 1 (p. 2)



world. The pow - ers of heaven therefore cried to You, O

Giv - er of Life: "Glory to Your Resur - rec - tion, O Christ!

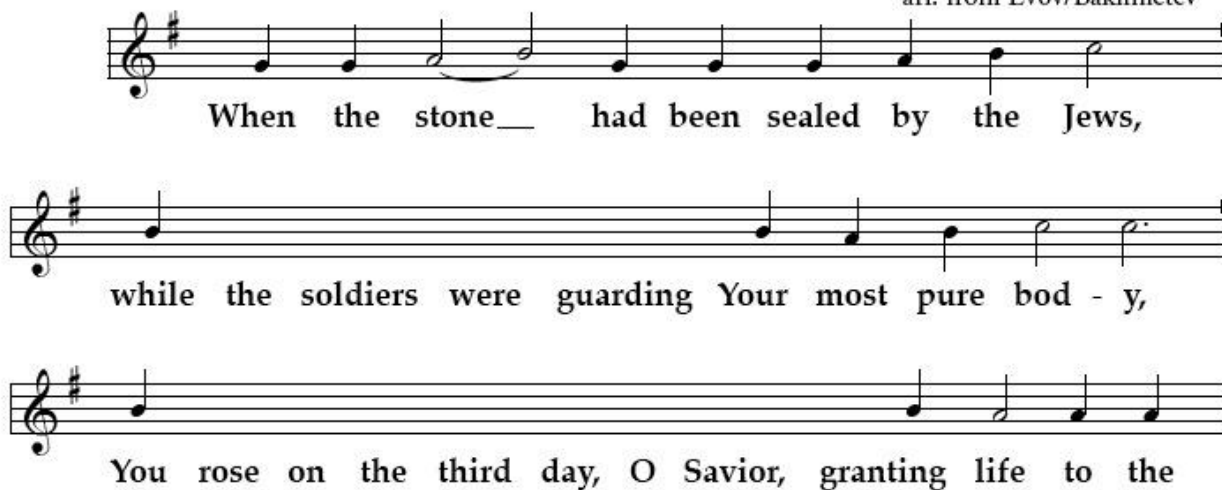
Glo - ry to Your King - dom! Glory to Your dispensation, O

Lov - er of man - kind!"

TROPARION TONE 1 (COMMON CHANT) - VARIANT 2 (p. 1)

TROPARION OF THE RESURRECTION Tone 1

Russian Imperial Court Chant
arr. from Lvov/Bakhmetev

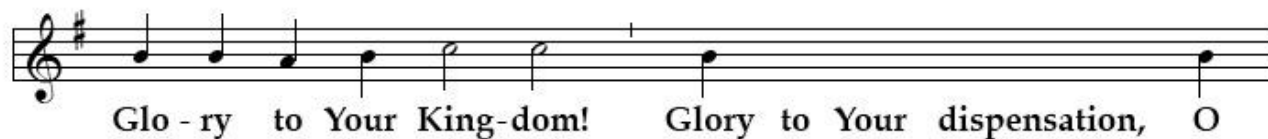
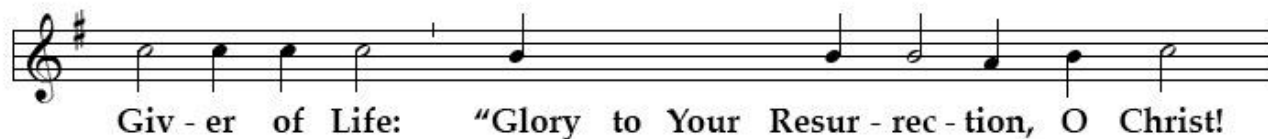
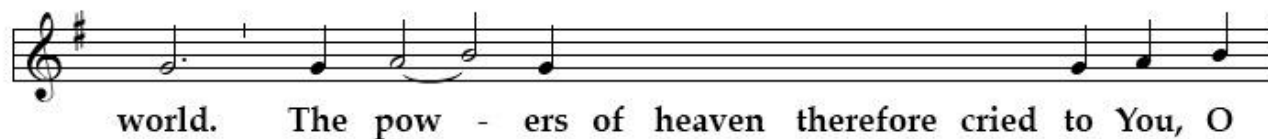


When the stone— had been sealed by the Jews,

while the soldiers were guarding Your most pure bod - y,

You rose on the third day, O Savior, granting life to the

TROPARION TONE 1 (COMMON CHANT) - VARIANT 2 (p. 2)



TROPARION TONE 2 (COMMON AND ABBREVIATED KIEVAN CHANTS) - ANALYSIS

There are two frequently used melodies used for troparia in Tone 2 — the so-called “Common” (Russian Imperial Chapel *Obikhod*) Chant, favored in St. Petersburg and Ukraine, and Abbreviated Kievan Chant, favored in Moscow (despite its designation as “Kievan”). Since a great many immigrants came to North America from the southern and western regions of the former Russian Empire, the Russian Imperial Chant version became more widely used in North American parishes. We present both melodies here.

Things to notice:

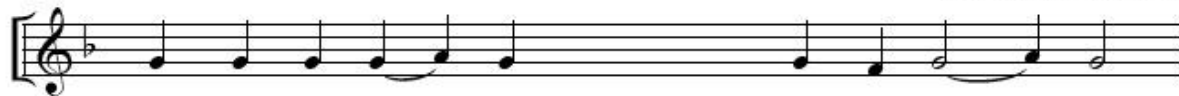
1. Both versions are typically written in the key of F (one flat in the key signature).
2. The Common Chant consists of two phrases (1,2) and a Final (see Form Analysis Exercises 6.1, Slide 3).
3. The Abbreviated Kievan Chant (see Slides 12 and 13 below), consists of Phrases 1, 2, and 3, with phrases 2 and 3 repeated as necessary, and closing with a Final phrase.

TROPARION TONE 2 ANALYSIS - 2

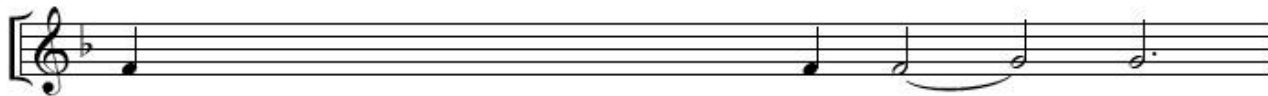
5. The Final Phrase of the Abbr. Kievan ends not on the tonic (F=DO), but on the leading tone (E=TI).
6. In practice, the Tone 2 Abbr. Kievan melody is also used for singing stichera as well as troparia, while the Tone 2 Common Chant melody is used **only** for singing troparia.

TROPARION OF THE RESURRECTION Tone 2

Abbr. Kievan Chant

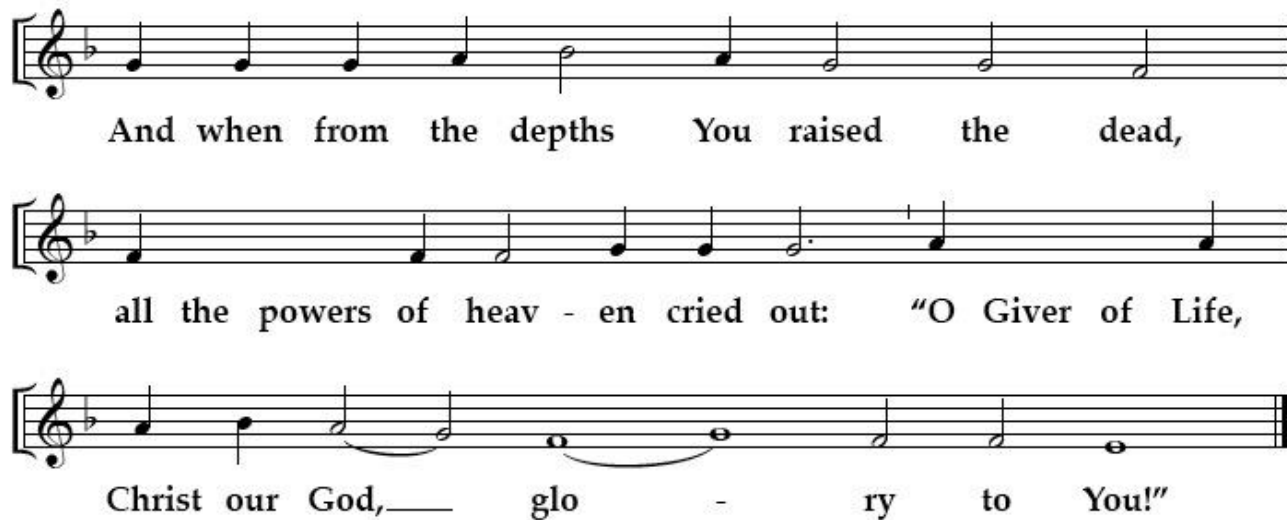


When You de-scend - ed to death, O Life Im - mor - tal,



You slew Hell with the splendor of Your God - head!

TROPARION TONE 2 (ABBR. KIEVAN CHANT) - (P. 2)



And when from the depths You raised the dead,
all the powers of heav - en cried out: "O Giver of Life,
Christ our God, — glo - ry to You!"

TROPARION TONE 3 - (COMMON, AKA “ABBREVIATED GREEK” CHANT) - ANALYSIS

The Common Chant Tone 3 melody used for troparia is sometimes also designated as “Abbreviated Greek Chant.” The origins of chant melodies called “Greek” in Eastern Slavic use date back to the 17th century, when Greek chanters and Russian pilgrims to the Holy Land brought these melodies to Ukraine and Moscow. Some of them bear a distant resemblance to Byzantine Tones (Tone 3 being of them), but it is appropriate to distinguish Russian “Greek” chants from modern-day Greek church melodies.

Things to notice:

1. Tone 3 Troparion melodies are typically written in the key of G (one sharp in the key signature), but they begin on E (LA); occasionally they are written in the key of F (starting on D).
2. From a musical standpoint, the Tone 3 Troparion melody is **rich** or **well developed**, spanning range of a fifth in its two initial phrases (from LA to MI and

TROPARION TONE 3 - ANALYSIS - 2

back); altogether the range of the melody spans a minor 7th, from LA to SOL— the only Tone that does this.

2. The structure of Troparion Tone 3 is more complex than other troparion Tones:
 - a. Phrases 1 and 2
 - b. followed by Phrase 1 and Phrase 3 then Phrase 2 again
 - c. then, if the text is long enough, Phrase 1 may be followed by Phrase 4
 - d. and the Final (see Form Analysis Exercises 6.1, Slide 4)
 - e. If the text is short, the Final Phrase may follow any of the above phrases.

ON THE SPOT EXERCISE:

Go back to Form Analysis Exercises 6.1, Example 2 (Slide 4) and compare your own analysis of the macrostructure to the above. Did you correctly identify Phrases 1 thru 4 and the Final?

TROPARION TONE 4 - (COMMON—TWO VARIANTS—AND “ABBREVIATED GREEK” CHANT) - ANALYSIS

The melodies used for Troparion Tone 4 consist of two melodic phrases (1 and 2) and a Final Phrase for the last line of text. Both in terms of their form and their melody, the Common (Russian Imperial Court) Chant and the Abbreviated Greek Chant are basically the same; the differences mostly result from how the melody is treated in harmonized choral arrangements. The Common Moscow Variant is slightly more rich or developed from a melodic standpoint.

Things to notice:

1. Tone 4 Troparia are typically written in F Major (1 flat) or G Major (1 sharp). The melody begins on DO.
2. In the Abbreviated Greek Chant version, the melody of Phrase 1 jumps to MI at the phrase ending. In the harmonized Common Chant version that leap DO-MI is given to the Bass part, while the voice carrying the melody (the Soprano or

TROPARION TONE 4 - ANALYSIS - 2

Alto) stays on DO, then moving up to RE and descending to DI (F# or G#, depending on the key. In Phrase 2, the melody returns from RE to DO.

3. By comparison with the Imperial Chapel Chant, the Moscow Synodal variant (Slides 22 & 23) has more melodic movement: it has a **beginning**—DO, RE, before reaching the **reciting tone** MI, and goes up to FA in the **ending** of Phrase 1; Phrase 2 also has a beginning—RE, MI, before reaching the reciting tone FA.

QUESTION:

If you were singing the service alone as a single chanter, which variant of Troparion Tone 4 would hold the worshippers' attention the most? The least? Why or why not?

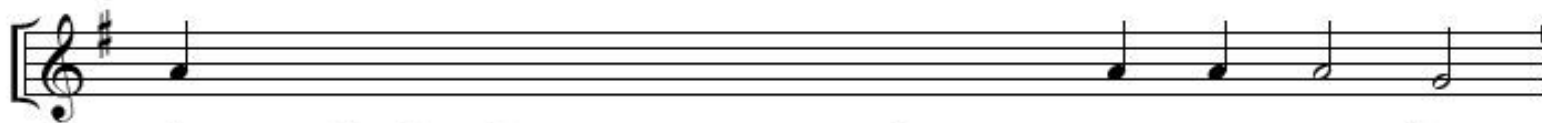
TROPARION TONE 4 (COMMON CHANT) (p. 1)

TROPARION OF THE RESURRECTION Tone 4

Russian Imperial Court Chant
arr. from Lvov/Bakhmetev



When the women dis - ci - ples of the Lord learned from



the angel the joyous message of Your Res - ur - rec - tion,

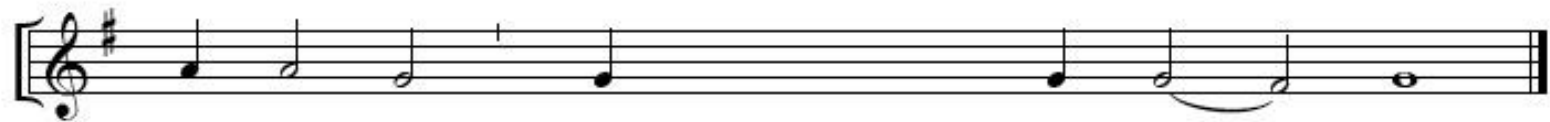
TROPARION TONE 4 (COMMON CHANT) (p. 2)



they cast away the an - ces - tral curse and elatedly told



the a - pos - tles: "Death is ov - er - thrown! Christ God



is ris - en, granting the world great mer - cy!"

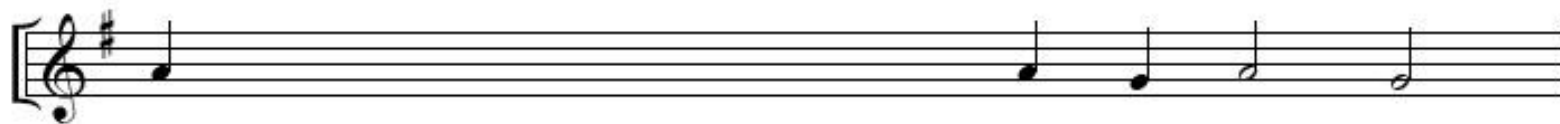
TROPARION TONE 4 (ABBR. GREEK CHANT) (p. 1)

TROPARION OF THE RESURRECTION Tone 4

Abbreviated Greek Chant



When the women dis - ci - ples of the Lord learned from



the angel the joyous message of Thy Res - ur - rec - tion,

TROPARION TONE 4 (ABBR. GREEK CHANT) (p. 2)

they cast away the an - ces - tral curse and e - lat - ed - ly

told the A - pos - tles: "Death is ov - er - thrown! Christ God

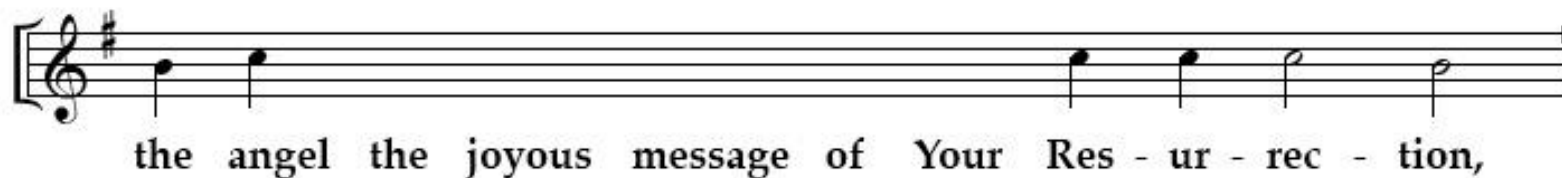
is ris - en, grant-ing the world great mer - cy!"

The image displays three staves of musical notation in G major (one sharp). The first staff contains the melody for the phrase "they cast away the an - ces - tral curse and e - lat - ed - ly". The second staff continues with "told the A - pos - tles: 'Death is ov - er - thrown! Christ God". The third staff concludes with "is ris - en, grant-ing the world great mer - cy!". The notation includes various note values (quarter, eighth, and half notes) and rests, with lyrics aligned beneath the corresponding notes.

TROPARION TONE 4 (MOSCOW COMMON CHANT) (p. 1)

TROPARION OF THE RESURRECTION Tone 4

Common Chant (Moscow Variant)
from the Synodal Choir *Obikhod*



TROPARION TONE 4 (MOSCOW COMMON CHANT) (p. 2)

they cast a - way the an - ces - tral curse and e - latedly told

the a - pos - tles: "Death is ov - er - thrown! Christ God

is ris - en, grant-ing the world great mer - cy!"

The image displays three staves of musical notation in G major (one sharp). The first staff contains the lyrics 'they cast a - way the an - ces - tral curse and e - latedly told'. The second staff contains 'the a - pos - tles: "Death is ov - er - thrown! Christ God'. The third staff contains 'is ris - en, grant-ing the world great mer - cy!'. The melody is written in a treble clef with a key signature of one sharp (F#). The notes are primarily quarter and half notes, with some rests. The lyrics are written in a serif font below the notes.

TROPARION TONE 5 (COMMON CHANT) ANALYSIS

As mentioned in our analysis of the sticheron melody for Tone 5, it consists of three melodic phrases (1, 2, 3), which are sung in rotation as many times as the text requires, plus a Final Phrase for the last line of text. The formal structure is 1, 2, 3, 1, 2, 3, 1, 2, 3, etc.... Final. Since the melody used for singing troparia in Tone 5 is identical, the same observations we made in Unit 7.1 are applicable here.

Things to notice:

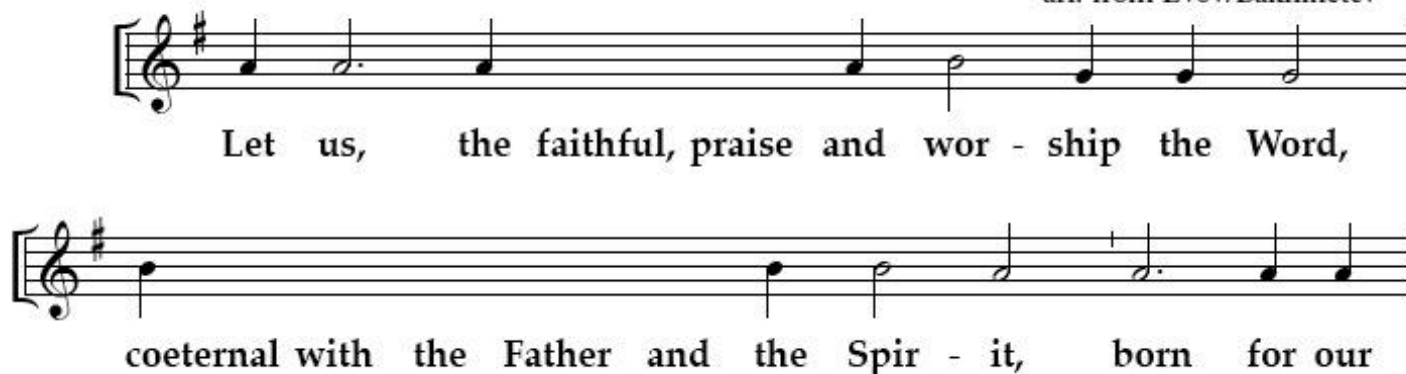
1. The key signature — one flat, suggests F Major or D Minor. Sometimes Tone 5 melodies are written in the key of G major (one sharp).
2. The starting note, G (RE), rises to A (MI), before dropping down to F (DO)
3. Phrase 2 begins on A (MI) and drops back to G (RE). Singing the A (MI) consistently high enough is crucial to singing this Tone in tune.
4. Phrase 3 ends on D (LA), again suggesting a feeling of a dual tonic—DO-LA.

TROPARION TONE 5 - (COMMON CHANT) - ANALYSIS

5. The Final phrase also ends on the note D (LA). In D Minor one would expect to see a C#, and indeed, C# shows up in the Final phrase of the four-part SATB harmonization.

TROPARION OF THE RESURRECTION Tone 5

Russian Imperial Court Chant
arr. from L'vov/Bakhmetev



Let us, the faithful, praise and wor - ship the Word,

coeternal with the Father and the Spir - it, born for our

TROPARION TONE 5 (COMMON CHANT) (P. 2)



salvation from the Vir - gin; for He willed to be lifted



up on the Cross in the flesh, to en-dure death, and to



raise the dead by His glo - rious Re-sur - rect - ion!

TROPARION TONE 6 (COMMON CHANT) - ANALYSIS

The troparion melody for Tone 6 consists of two melodic phrases (1, 2), which are sung in alternation as many times as the text requires. There is no distinct Final Phrase: the last line of text is sung to Phrase 2. The formal structure is 1, 2, 1, 2, 1, 2, etc. Please refer to Form Analysis Exercises 6.1 (Slide 5).

Things to notice:

1. The key signature — one sharp, indicates G Major or E Minor, though sometimes Troparion Tone 6 is written in F Major.
2. Phrase 1 begins on G (DO) as a reciting tone and rises through RE to MI, and then drops to RE. Phrase 2 has a similar melodic shape, starting on TI, rising through DO to RE before dropping again through DO to TI.
3. The melody does not end on the tonic DO, but rather on TI.
4. In some places, such as Moscow, this melody is not used; instead Sticheron Tone 6 is used for troparia as well.

TROPARION TONE 7 (COMMON CHANT) - ANALYSIS

Similar to Tone 2, the sticheron melody for Tone 7 consists of two melodic phrases (1 and 2), repeated as many times as the text requires, and a Final Phrase for the last line of text. The resulting formal structure is: 1, 2, 1, 2, 1, 2 ... Final. Please refer to Form Analysis Exercises 6.1 (Slide 6).

Things to notice:

1. Troparion Tone 7 is usually written in the key of F Major, with a key signature of one flat, but it can also be seen occasionally in other keys.
2. In the key of F, Phrase 1 usually begins on A (MI) and ascends to B-flat (FA) before descending through MI to the reciting tone RE; it then ascends again to MI, FA in the phrase ending.
3. Phrase 2 remains on FA as a reciting tone before descending to MI.
4. Only in the Final Phrase does the melody finally come to rest on DO, confirming the it as the tonic.

TROPARION TONE 8 (COMMON CHANT AND KIEVAN CAVES MONASTERY CHANT) – ANALYSIS

In terms of its structure, the Common Chant melody for Troparion Tone 8 is the simplest one of all, consisting of only one phrase. This makes every textual phrase “equal in importance,” so to speak, from a musical standpoint.

By contrast, the melody of the Kievan Caves Monastery for Troparion Tone 8 (see Form Analysis Exercises 6.1, Slide 7) has a two-phrase structure, similar to what we have already seen in Tones 1 (1st variant), 2, 4, 6, and 7. This makes it particularly suitable for texts that have a similar structure.

Things to notice:

1. Troparia in Tone are typically written in G Major, sometimes in F Major.
2. The melodic structure for the Common Chant version found in most authoritative sources is a beginning —DO, RE, MI, FA, a reciting tone MI, and an ending RE, DO. However, there is also a popular variant that begins: MI, RE, MI, FA, and has an ending RE, MI.

TROPARION TONE 8 - (COMMON CHANT)

TROPARION OF THE RESURRECTION Tone 8

Russian Imperial Court Chant
arr. from L'vov/Bakhmetev



You de-scend-ed from on high, O Mer - ci - ful One!



You en - dured the three - day burial to free us from



our suf - fer - ings! O Lord, our Life and Res - ur - rec - tion,



glo - ry to You!

Proceed to **FORM ANALYSIS EXERCISES 8.1**



Liturgical Music & Texts